dipped and I reached my fifty with a scoring rate of over 150 for the innings.

This innings must rank as one of the best I have played because of the immense pressure it was played under. Each boundary brought me an ovation from the raucous crowd. Wearing the tricolour on my helmet on sport's biggest stage against the nation's premier opposition while being watched by close to a billion fans – what more could I have asked for? I just had to bat Pakistan out of the game.

It was in my seventies that I started cramping up. I received some treatment but refused to have a runner as I have always been uncomfortable with someone else running for me. My concentration was affected and much as I would have liked to power on, it wasn't possible. I eventually got out to a short ball from Shoaib Akhtar for 98. In that physical state I found it difficult to get up on my toes to keep the rising ball down. I walked back to a standing ovation.

Importantly, we still had a deficit of 96 runs and my innings would have little value if we lost a couple of quick wickets. There was no need to fear, as Rahul and Yuvraj took control and finished the match with almost five overs to spare. They both made half-centuries and India had won a famous contest, continuing our run of success against Pakistan in World Cups.

I felt very proud when I went out to receive the Man of the Match award, a watch. It was one for all our passionate fans back home. I called a number of my friends in India and was told that the country had erupted in celebrations. We were glad we could give our people such a moment to cherish.

Nobody wanted to call a halt to the celebrations in the dressing room, until finally the team decided to go out for something to eat, as we were all starving. It was close to midnight and we ended up going to a roadside stall for Chinese food. My friends Sunil Harshe and Sanjay Narang, there to cheer on the Indian team, also came along, and it was over our dinner of noodles that I decided to give Sanjay my Man of the Match watch to take back to Mumbai.

Some time later, after we had finished dinner and were on our way back to the hotel, Sanjay panicked. He told me that he had left the watch at the Chinese food stall. At first I thought he was joking, but he wasn't and he said he would never joke about something as precious as a World Cup Man of the Match award. He immediately called the stall and told